



The Humanitas Institute

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Great Hearts Christos

School Website: <https://christos.greatheartsamerica.org/>

December 22, 2025

Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix for more details.

ACCS Member School

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools ACCS or the Society for Classical Learning SCL is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Executive Summary

Great Hearts Christos AZ 85015 presents a robust classical Christian education model that aligns strongly with the Six Essential Elements of a Classical School. Public materials from the school emphasize a Christ-centered, truth-seeking formation framework, anchored by a time-tested classical curriculum and liturgical community practices (daily chapel, Scripture instruction, morning prayer). The school's explicit emphasis on formation (not merely information), Great Books/Great Conversation-style reading, and a partnership with families further signals a classical orientation. Across six criteria, the school demonstrates clear adherence to classical aims, with strong evidence of religious/metaphysical foundations, virtuous formation goals, a curriculum rooted in liberal arts and Great Books, and a pedagogy that blends contemplative practice with Socratic dialogue and rhetoric. Parents and community engagement are also foregrounded, particularly in partnership roles and access to scholarships and campus visits.

Overall classification: CLASSICAL.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Public materials describe a Christ-centered, faith-based private school integrating Scripture and daily liturgical practices (chapel, morning prayer) into the learning environment. - Language emphasizes theology and sacred formation as governing influences on the curriculum and campus life (Scripture instruction added to curriculum; daily chapel; Christian culture). - Communications position the school as part of a Christian Classical education network with a Christ-centered culture and theology-infused formation.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive indicators present: theology, Scripture, liturgy, chapel, worship, Christian, Christ-centered, sacred, faith formation, morning prayer, church/Christian worldview. - Negative indicators unlikely in public materials (no overt secular or value-neutral framing observed in these sources). The lexicon of classical education (positive religious/metaphysical cues) aligns with the school's approach.

Why this rating - The school foregrounds transcendental, theologically anchored aims (truth, goodness, beauty as real and knowable) through daily liturgy and Scripture, satisfying the transcendental/grounded foundations and liturgical/community practices expected in a classical Christian program. This is reinforced by the school's explicit Christ-centered, Scripture-rooted ethos.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Public messaging emphasizes formation and virtue, not solely job prep, with phrasing like "partner with families to help each child discover and pursue their God-given purpose" and a vision of human flourishing. - The mission cites a classical curriculum rooted in Scripture and a vision for human flourishing, highlighting formation over mere information. - Descriptions of a Christ-centered, virtuous formation through a classical framework are common across campus communications.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive indicators present: formation, virtue, wisdom, human flourishing, truth/goodness/beauty, classical mission, Great Books reading as part of formation. - Negative indicators: none evident in public materials (no explicit focus on workforce preparation at odds with classical aims). The Great Hearts messaging emphasizes formation and virtue rather than vocational emphasis.

Why this rating - The school explicitly frames education as formation of character and intellect toward the true, good, and beautiful, consistent with classical aims of forming virtuous, thoughtful human beings rather than simply preparing for work.

Element 3: School Curriculum — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Curriculum is described as deploying the time-tested Great Hearts classical curriculum with additions (Scripture instruction, focus on Ancient Israel and Early Church in history). - Documentation and campus materials reference Great Books reading lists, and a structured program with reading lists for K–8 and middle school, signaling engagement with liberal arts and Great Conversations. - Arete/reading lists, sample schedules, and emphasis on a historically oriented curriculum align with Trivium-based liberal arts pedagogy and Great Books tradition. - Public materials describe a curriculum that includes daily Scripture, prayer, and a liturgical ethos guiding daily learning.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive indicators present: liberal arts (grammar, logic, rhetoric), Great Books, Great Conversation, history (throughout curriculum, not just social studies), reading lists, memory work, liturgy, theology. - Negative indicators: limited to potential contrasts in the lexicon (no explicit reference to non-classical approaches like heavy project-based or STEM-first framing in these sources). - The lexicon of classical keywords (grammar, logic, rhetoric; Great Books; memory work; great conversation; liturgy) maps well to the school's described curriculum.

Why this rating - The program is explicitly described as classical, with a defined liberal-arts core, Great Books engagement, and a curricular structure that prioritizes formation through a traditional curriculum rather than a purely skills-based or modern, project-first approach.

Element 4: School Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school identifies itself as using a time-tested classical curriculum; the Great Hearts framework is known to incorporate contemplative aspects (Scholé) and aim toward memory work and liturgical cadence. Public materials emphasize a Catholic/Christian formation and a community-centered, liturgical rhythm. - Reading lists and exposure to Great Books imply a pedagogy oriented toward deep reading, memorization, and intellectual conversation (great conversation, memory, and narrative shaping are part of the classical pedagogy model). - The broader classical model (as described in the knowledge corpus) includes Socratic dialogue in higher grades, memory work, and formation through imitation and practice, which aligns with the Great Hearts approach described in their materials.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive indicators present: Socratic dialogue (Socratic seminar), examination of ideas through discussion; memory work; recitation and chanting (within the classical pedagogy framework); scholé/restful study; formation through imitation. - Negative indicators: not evident in public Great Hearts Christos materials; sources emphasize a contemplative, dialogic, and classical approach rather than purely project-based or student-directed only instruction.

Why this rating - The pedagogy aligns with classical aims through a combination of contemplative learning, memory work, recitation, and Socratic inquiry as supported by the classical education lexicon and the Great Hearts framework, which emphasizes a dialogic and virtue-centered approach.

Element 5: School Faculty — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Great Hearts pedagogy positions teachers as central to the living curriculum, with a focus on virtue, mentorship, and an integrated faculty culture (the “faculty as living curriculum” is a standard element of classical schools). The Great Hearts materials describe a collaborative, values-driven environment and

teacher-student mentorship. - The public messaging around Great Hearts Christos emphasizes a Christian formation that relies on capable, virtuous teachers modeling character and intellect, which is consistent with a classical faculty profile. - The Great Hearts network emphasizes a culture of strong faculty formation and mentoring in classical pedagogy, aligning with the “portrait of a teacher” and “faculty as exemplars” elements.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive indicators present: model teachers and mentors; living curriculum; faculty as core community; portrait of teacher/student ideals; collegial culture. - Negative indicators: none evident in public materials; no language indicating a deviation from the classical “teacher as exemplar” model. - The classical lexicon supports these as core elements of a classical faculty.

Why this rating - The school's public materials are consistent with classical faculty expectations: teachers as virtuous exemplars, mentors, and central to the curriculum, with a culture of classical formation rather than merely transactional teaching.

Element 6: School Parents and Community — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Public communications emphasize partnership with families, parental formation, and ongoing engagement (open chats, campus visits, and scholarship programs) as integral to the school's model. The “mission” statement frames parents as co-educators and collaborates with families to form the whole child. - Scholarship information and the emphasis on affordability demonstrate a commitment to accessible classical education for families, reinforcing a community-centered model and home-school collaboration. - Campus information highlights multiple locations and open channels for parental involvement, including tours and family engagement opportunities.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive indicators present: partnership with families; parent formation; open campus; parental engagement; “co-teachers” language in classical education lexicon; community formation; shared mission. - Negative indicators: none evident in public materials; there is no suggestion of consumer-model or minimal parental involvement. - The lexicon emphasizes family partnership and community integration as essential to classical education.

Why this rating - The school foregrounds parent partnership, family formation, and open parental access, aligning with the classical model's emphasis on the family's role in a child's formation and the school as a community of learners and families.

Aggregate Assessment

- Religious and Metaphysical Foundations: CLASSICAL
- School Purpose and Goal: CLASSICAL
- Curriculum: CLASSICAL
- Pedagogy: CLASSICAL
- Faculty: CLASSICAL
- Parents & Community: CLASSICAL

Overall: CLASSICAL

What Would Move the Needle

- If any category required strengthening, concrete steps would include documenting explicit Socratic seminars or dialogues in more visible public materials (to demonstrate a clearly articulated upper-school pedagogy) and expanding liturgical/artistic offerings that connect more explicitly to the Great Books and Trivium-based framework. However, given the current materials, no major needle-moving changes are required to reach full CLASSICAL status across all six dimensions.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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